

RESEARCH

Open Access



Fairness in language classroom assessment practices: what do EFL teachers underscore?

Mohammad Ahmadi Safa^{1*}  and Bahare Nasiri¹

*Correspondence:
m.ahmadisafa@basu.ac.ir;
ahmadisafa@gmail.com

¹ Department of English,
Humanities Faculty, Bu-Ali Sina
University, Hamedan, Iran

Abstract

Studies have confirmed that fair assessment practices in educational contexts affect learners' motivation, self-regulation, and above all teacher credibility, yet the concept has been subject to educational stakeholders' diverse outlooks and perspectives. On this basis, this study delves into the high school English as Foreign Language (EFL) teachers' understanding and perceptions of fairness of assessment practices in Iranian educational contexts. Thus, 105 conveniently selected EFL teachers of Junior/Senior high schools took the Classroom Assessment Fairness Scale (CAFS) consisting of 35 Likert scale items that tap into the five dimensions of the concept. The obtained questionnaire data were subjected to descriptive and inferential statistical analyses, the results of which revealed that Iranian English teachers were cognizant of different principles of fairness in classroom assessment, and they were quite conscious of the significance of its different components. Additionally, the findings demonstrated that there was no notable difference in the perceptions of EFL teachers in terms of their teaching context. The findings might have a couple of implications: First, classroom assessment fairness seems to be both an established concept in Iranian EFL contexts, and of the EFL teachers' concern. Second, teaching contexts seem not to affect the EFL teachers' conceptions of what constitutes a fair classroom assessment practice.

Keywords: Fairness, Classroom assessment, EFL teachers, Teaching context

Introduction

The crucial role of assessment in education is more than obvious to educators (Shah Ahmadi & Ketabi, 2019) and although fairness of assessment is at the heart of this process (Mazzoli Smith et al., 2018), it has relatively been underappreciated in classroom assessment practices (Tofighi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023). In theory though, fairness is considered a fundamental criterion for evaluating the quality of tests and assessments from Standards for Educational and Psychological Testing perspective (AERA et al., 2014) and "is a fundamental validity component that requires attention throughout all stages of test development and use" (AERA et al., 2014, p. 49). The teachers' concerns about being fair in assessment stem from diverse intentional and unintentional consequences of the application of tests and assessment practices in test takers' life. In other words, the concept of fairness does not refer to a property of a test per se, but its use (Camilli, 2006).

Educational assessment experts have underscored the importance of fairness in assessment to the extent that some have called for a major shift in the primary focus of assessment theory, as altering from the traditional perspective including double fundamental criteria, i.e., Validity and Reliability, to triple fundamental criteria perspective, i.e., Validity, Reliability, and Fairness (Messick, 1988). The call is on the grounds that the researchers have come to the realization that the evaluations of tests for technical attributes including validity and reliability have underestimated the significance of fairness since it has never been a predominant focus explicitly recognized or emphasized (Kunnan, 1997). On the other hand and from a less theoretical stance, the teachers' conceptions of fair and equitable assessment referring to their intellectual frameworks, comprising not only of belief system but whole aspects of their knowledge related to their experienced issues (Thompson, 1992), influence the learners' educational and psychosocial outcomes (Elwood & Murphy, 2015; Moss et al., 2005) due to the fact that the way students perceive test fairness impacts their incitement and effort, and can lead to outcomes such as objection and retribution toward the teacher (Chory-Assad & Paulsel, 2004). In contrast, instructors who are known to give fair tests have credibility from the test takers' perspective (Chory, 2007).

The studies focusing on fairness and ethicality of assessment in the classroom have not been scarce in recent years (e.g., Green et al., 2007; Fan et al., 2017; Fan et al., 2019; Fan et al., 2020); however, only a few of them have empirically delved into the teachers' perception of fair classroom assessment (Rasooli et al., 2022; Tierney, 2014; Tofighi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023). Moreover, when it comes to the impact of context on the teachers' perception of the concept, studies have been even limited in number (Tofighi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023). On this basis, considering the fact that there are notable differences between the conditions of teachers in both public and private schools in terms of income level, benefits, and job security and even social status in Iranian educational contexts, the researchers in this study aimed to explore the possible impacts of teaching contexts on the EFL teachers' perception of fairness in classroom assessment.

Review of the related literature: theoretical background

The fairness of educational assessment and testing practices has always been of crucial significance, yet it has gained heightened importance in recent years as test applications and functions are being extensively expanded to incorporate differing populations, complex purposes, and functions in various virtual and real contexts; however, defining what makes up a fair assessment in these contexts has not been an easy task given that educational assessment fairness is viewed from a wide range of perspectives (AERA et al., 2014), and its conceptual definition is yet in need of empirical validation (Nisbet, 2017). Together with or as substitutes of fairness, terms like justice, equity, equality, equitability, ethicality, and unprejudiced practices are applied in diverse conceptualizations (Rasooli et al., 2018). Further, many experts in the field believe that research in this area has consistently centered on concerns of fairness, along with related issues such as bias, justice, and equality within the context of evaluating tests based on the principles of validity and reliability (Kunnan, 2008). However, unlike the complexity of its definition and ambiguity of the concept, commonalities exist on two points: firstly, fairness is a matter of degree so it cannot be determined dichotomously (Cole & Zieky, 2001; Lane

& Silver, 1999); secondly, while different from validity, it is a crucial validity attribute and closely interconnected with it (Camilli, 2006; Messick, 2000; Stobart, 2005). Kunnan (2008) even maintains that validity is at the core of the Test Fairness Framework (TFF).

The binomial equality-equity, which links fair assessment to either the concept of equality or the concept of equity, may be one of the biggest obstacles to the conceptualization of fair assessment (Nisbet & Shaw, 2019). In order to attain objectivity, equal assessment necessitates identical process, content, scoring system, and interpretation of the results (Murillo & Hidalgo, 2020). Many scholars consider impartiality and equity as fundamental premises for a fair assessment, and to ensure that student diversity is appropriately weighed throughout the assessment process, they define equity principle as the application of multiple assessments with various instruments (Camilli, 2013; Nisbet, 2019; Tierney, 2014, 2016). Proponents of this idea argue that not every student may necessarily have equal access to educational opportunities; consequently, the principle of equality is a form of injustice rather than justice (Scott et al., 2014; Shiba et al., 2015; Suskie, 2002).

Educational Testing Service Standards for Quality and Fairness claim that for test developers, the most practical definition of fairness is the degree to which the conclusions drawn from test scores are accurate and applicable for various groups of test takers (ETS, 2014). In order for test results to produce proper inferences for intended purposes, an assessment procedure is said to be fair if it is sensitive to the unique characteristics of each individual and the testing context (ETS, 2014).

In a further contemplation of the binomial equality-equity, four interpretations of fairness are conceivable (AERA et al., 1999). Among them, lack of bias in statistical measurements and the impartial treatment of examinees throughout the testing process, are widely acknowledged in the measurement community (Tierney, 2014). Arguing that differences in group scores do not always signify bias in the test, Messick and Anderson (1970) criticize the interpretation of fairness as merely the equality of test outcomes in a third interpretation. The fourth interpretation that links fairness to opportunity for learning experiences is criticized as well; however, it is recognized that in order for test results to be fair, prior exposure to the test materials is inevitable (Tierney, 2014).

Kunnan (2008) proposed an ethics-based rationale in his seminal Test Fairness Framework (TFF) and outlined a set of guiding principles and sub-principles including two overarching principles of *Justice* and *beneficence* and their associated sub-principles. From this point of view, justice refers to an underlying expectation that every individual is treated with equal respect while beneficence refers to the point that a test should contribute positively to society and it must not cause harm or have adverse effects in society. According to this framework, test fairness is best served when five fairness qualities including, validity, absence of bias, access, administration, and social consequences are taken into consideration.

In addition, the characterization of fair assessment practice has also been recently at the focus of researchers' attention. Herman and Cook (2019) for instance, argue that scores obtained in a fair test reflect the same underlying construct and are equivalent in terms of meaning for each individual testee and there is no bias based on factors that are irrelevant to the construct being assessed. Correspondingly underscoring the significance of construct relevance, AERA et al. (2014) proposed that every step in the

testing procedure, i.e., test designing, validating, developing, administering, and scoring must be structured in a way to reduce variance irrelevant to the construct and to ensure validity in interpretations of score for the intended uses for every examinee in the target population.

Mislevy (2018) contends that test fairness concerns a rational basis for adjusting to the interests and prior knowledge of the testees and underscores the importance of understanding the way in which a test is applied given the individual(s), its background, task, and context. In order for assessment practices to be considered fair, instead of acting as tools for classification, they have to be viewed as tools for diagnosis; instead of acting as external instruments to gauge students' practice, they must help to boost student learning, and above all rather than acting as means of penalizing those who fall short of the required standards, they must level out the overall students' evaluation (Peters et al., 2017).

As a major subgroup of assessment practices, Classroom Assessment (CA) fairness calls for the teachers' updated knowledge concerning students' learning and development. Consequently, complete fairness in CA is quite hard to achieve; it is a continuing effort that undulates in intensity with the ways of teaching, learning, and assessment (Tierney, 2014). Aiming at an increased level of classroom assessment fairness, Rogers (1996) proposed a set of standards and a guideline to characterize equitable and fair CA practices. From his perspective, to ensure a fair CA, it is inevitable to employ diverse assessment methods that are aligned with predetermined learning goals; make students aware of the assessment criteria that will be applied and give explicit instructions on what they are expected to be capable of; employ assessments that correspond with the kind of learning that students are required to acquire; provide every student with a thorough explanation of the assessment results, accompanied by making sure they accurately represent each student's learning process, and together with oral feedback to fine-tune their learning, provide each student a personalized report that includes comprehensive details about their assessment.

In addition, some common guiding principles prevailing in the literature which appear to capture the quintessence of a fair CA practice encompass a variety of factors including, chance for learning development, unambiguity in assessment procedures, criticality about assessment practices, productive classroom environment, and an equilibrium between equity and equality (Tierney, 2014); evaluative thinking and a set of strategies, centered on giving people the chance to demonstrate what they have learned and the transparency principle (Tierney, 2016); the principle of do no harm (Taylor & Nolen, 2005) and to score pollution avoidance (Haladyna et al., 1991; Popham, 1991).

Previous research findings

Among the studies concentrating on the conceptions of teachers and students on ethicality of classroom assessment (e.g., Azizi, 2022; Fan et al., 2017, 2019, 2020; Flores et al., 2015), many have specifically focused on fairness conception in classroom assessment practices (e.g., Alm & Colnerud, 2015; Azizi, 2022; Chory-Assad, 2002; Darabi Bazvand & Rasooli, 2022; Green et al., 2007; Murillo & Hidalgo, 2017, 2020; Rasooli et al., 2018, 2019, 2022; Scott et al., 2014; Tierney, 2013; Tofighi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023; Torkey & Sayed Haider, 2017). Flores et al. (2015), for example, explored undergraduate students'

opinions on effectiveness, fairness, and feedback. The analyses of the data gathered from 378 students indicated that those who were assessed through active participation methods conceptualized assessment as a fair and effective procedure in contrast with those who were assessed through more conventional means like written tests and exams. Alm and Colnerud (2015), on the other hand, focused on the aspects of teachers' performance that contribute to the perception of unfairness from the learners' perspective. The study applied critical incident technique and explored the personal accounts of 411 Swedish teachers who shared their personal accounts of being assessed in school context. The primary findings demonstrated that the participants felt the grading process was unfair when teachers disregarded the rules of the current grading system, applied undependable information, gave in to irrelevant factors, or communicated vaguely. Murillo and Hidalgo (2017) also investigated the ideas of elementary and secondary school students regarding what makes an assessment fair. The results obtained through a phenomenographic study with 32 participants once again highlighted the binomial equality- equity. Equalitarian perspective of fair assessment, centered on equality, transparency, objectivity, and evaluation of course material. Conversely, equity oriented conception favored concepts like adaptation, test diversification, and subjectivity.

In the context of the Iranian higher education system, Rasooli et al. (2019) examined the critical incidents of fair and/or unfair issues experienced by college students, as well as their emotional and behavioral reactions to these experiences. The results indicated that distributive, procedural, and interactional justice were all part of the students' conceptions of CA fairness. Students referred to negative emotions like, anger, upsetness, frustration, and shamefulness in their accounts of unfair testing incidents. Describing fair experiences on the other hand, they mentioned positive emotions like, delight, contentment, appreciated feelings, and hopefulness. Students also mentioned that fair incidents led to their increased engagement in class activities and flexibility, whereas unfair incidents led to their less engagement in classroom, disapproval feelings, and inactivity.

Moreover, in the same Iranian context, Tofghi and Ahmadi Safa (2023) studied fairness in foreign language assessment from the viewpoint of EFL teachers. Analyses of the data gathered from 120 EFL teachers indicated that they were rather familiar with classroom assessment practices' fairness principles. However, the teachers' standpoint was statistically different in terms of their gender, education level, teaching background, and instructional context. Following Tofghi and Ahmadi Safa (2023), the present study included fairness principles of equal chances to learn, unambiguity, the chance to indicate learning, do-no-harm principle, and score pollution avoidance in its definition of test fairness. The *chance to learn* principle pertains to being familiar with the content being tested or, in a broader sense, to the consistency between the assessment and curriculum. Additionally, it might encompass various socioeconomic and educational factors that promote learning (Tierney, 2016). *Unambiguity* encompasses the idea that prior to an assessment, students ought to be aware of how their work will be evaluated. The *chance to indicate* learning is giving students numerous, distinct, fair, and meaningful opportunities to exhibit what they have learned (Tierney, 2016). The *do-no-harm principle* is congruent with the basic premise that ethical standards ought to safeguard the rights of those impacted by an assessment and not suggest a disregard for student rights and needs (Airasian, 2005; Green et al., 2007).

Pollution of score occurs when the test score fails to accurately reflect a student's true attainment of the content area and is contaminated by factors irrelevant to academic performance (Green et al., 2007). Thus, the *score pollution avoidance* principle emphasizes that learners' scores should be free from factors that are unrelated to the construct (Green et al., 2007) and those that are underrepresented within the construct (Rasooli et al., 2018).

Further, Darabi Bazvand and Rasooli (2022) examined postgrad university students' conceptions of fairness in summative assessments and revealed that the concepts of interactional fairness and equity were fundamental meter of fair or unfair assessment.

Additionally, Rezaei et al. (2021) investigated Iranian university teachers' perceptions of the core principles for language assessment literacy. Data collected from 18 university teachers across Iranian universities highlighted the teachers' adherence to several key factors including, adhering to ethical standards, prioritizing performance-based assessments, accounting for students' individual differences, ensuring the validity and reliability of assessments, involving students in the assessment process, adopting alternative assessment methods, providing students with feedback on test results, administering tests in a standardized manner, and employing valid grading practices; all of which are regarded as inevitable prerequisites for ensuring test fairness. Furthermore, Rezaei et al. (2022) aimed to explore Iranian university teachers' perceptions regarding the impact of demographic biases such as gender, ethnicity, and socioeconomic status on the fairness of their assessment practices. The answers from 15 university teachers participating in the study indicated that gender bias is common in assessment practices, ethnicity bias negatively influences assessment processes, and socioeconomic status bias undermines fairness in assessments, highlighting that these can significantly contribute to score contamination in classroom assessment practices.

Saudi Arabian teachers' approaches to classroom assessment within the higher education context were examined in Almossa and Alzahrani (2022). This study that focused on assessment purposes, processes, fairness, and measurement theory encompassed four dimensions of teachers' assessment approaches within the classroom. The data obtained from 287 participants demonstrated that among the identified modules, fairness was the least valued aspect. However, experienced teachers who considered themselves competent in their roles put greater emphasis on assessment fairness and measurement theory compared to their novice counterparts.

Murillo and Hidalgo (2020) also concentrated on the teachers' perception and aimed at exploring how the teachers conceptualize a fair assessment. Results from a phenomenographic study involving 30 teachers in Spanish primary and secondary schools indicated that teachers' conceptualization of fair assessment varied, with some aligning more with the equity principle and others with equality. The study concluded that how teachers perceive the constitution of fair assessment is significantly context-dependent, in line with the results obtained in Tofghi and Ahmadi Safa (2023) and Rasooli et al. (2022). Rasooli et al. (2022), interviewing 27 expert high school teachers to understand the dimensions shaping their conceptions of fairness, found that three main factors including social systems, individual systems, and the logical relationships between social and individual systems influence their perceptions of what constitutes fair classroom assessment.

Azizi (2022) also explored university English professors' perceptions of fair assessment practices in online educational platforms of Iran. To this end, 21 university English teachers partook in the study. The findings identified that similar to assessment practices in traditional classrooms, fairness remains a central principle in online education assessments. Three significant concepts—distributive, procedural, and interactional justice—were recognized as the most important components of fair assessment arguing that design, implementation, and evaluation of assessment practices should be performed in a manner that ensures students' perception of fair assessment practices.

Against the backdrop of the reviewed brief literature, it was evident that although the number of studies investigating both teachers' and students' perception of the concept was growing, the influence of teaching contextual variables on the teachers' conceptualization of fairness was still an underexplored aspect of classroom assessment fairness conceptualization. On this basis and given the heightened importance of fair and equitable classroom assessment practices, the researchers developed the following research questions:

1. What are Iranian high school teachers' articulated conceptions of fairness in classroom assessment?
2. Is there any statistically significant difference between teachers' perception of fairness in terms of teaching context?

Context of study

The National Curriculum Document (NCD) of Iran sets principles and standards for the preparation of the teachers for classroom assessment in the Iranian educational system (Ministry of Education, 2010). In operational terms, ten principles are set for sound classroom assessment practices by NCD: (1) teachers must be capable of exploiting various methods to conduct learner assessment; (2) the teachers should furnish sufficient proof to precisely gauge performance of student in alignment with the educative benchmarks; (3) considering the distinct learning path of individual students, it is imperative for the teacher to elucidate the subsequent stages for learning; (4) focusing on student self-assessment, it is crucial for teachers to assist students in extracting meaningful lessons from their mistakes to improve the learning process; (5) to safeguard the dignity of students and preserve a positive self-identity, educators should refrain from employing assessment methods that cause anxiety; (6) to gain a thorough insight into various dimensions of student learning, both students and their parents should be involved in the assessment process; (7) according to the general principles established by the Ministry of Education, both teachers and schools are regarded as primary decision makers, whose critical role should be maintained in assessment; (8) while in primary schools assessment focuses on process-oriented evidence, in secondary schools the concentration needs to be balanced between process together with product-oriented evidences; (9) to reduce rivalry among students, assessment should include collaborative tasks and problem-solving activities; and (10) with its outcomes serving to guide and enhance instruction assessment should be an essential component of the instructional process (Ministry of Education, 2010). Although these principles do not directly refer to fairness, they appear to call for fair

and equitable assessments through multiple assessments, upholding student dignity, and the application of formative assessment methods (Rasooli et al., 2022).

Considering funding and management of educational institutions and schools in the Iranian general education system either the state (public schools) or the private sector are in charge, both of which follow a standardized national curriculum set by the Ministry of Education. Public schools are government funded and free for all students to attend. Private schools, on the other hand, are independently funded by the private sector and open to those who can afford the tuition fee. They have more flexibility in choosing their curriculum and teaching methods and school policies. They often have smaller classes in terms of the number of class takers and may offer additional resources and extracurricular programs. While public schools offer education to the masses and promote equality in access to education, private schools provide additional choices and resources for families who can afford them. In terms of the teachers, there are notable differences between the conditions of those who are teaching in public and private schools. They might differ in terms of salary, benefits, job security, and job satisfaction. Typically, there exists a notable disparity in the prevalence of burnout between public school teachers and their peers in private schools. Factors such as economic situation, job stability, social class, demotivation, and absence of peace and tranquility are identified as primary contributors to burnout among teachers in private educational settings (Bahrami & Moradkhani, 2019). On the other hand, teachers in public schools are generally in better conditions in terms of salary, compared to their counterparts in private settings; they frequently enjoy enhanced benefits such as health insurance, retirement options, and opportunities for professional development. Public school teachers are usually hired on a permanent basis and tend to exhibit higher levels of satisfaction in comparison to their counterparts in private schools employed on a contract basis (Naeem Akhtar et al., 2010).

Methodology

Design of the study

This survey study applied a questionnaire to collect the required quantitative data to document teachers' conception of fair assessment in classroom practices and recognize the degree to which the perceptions differ in terms of the context of education, including public/private, junior/senior secondary programs. The variables of the study were the teachers' conception of classroom assessment fairness as was measured through CAFS and the teachers' teaching context.

Participants

The participants of the study were 105 Iranian EFL teachers selected through convenience sampling from public and private junior and senior secondary schools of different cities of Iran. At the outset of the study, they expressed their informed consent to partake in the study, and they were assured of the confidentiality of the collected data. The participants' descriptive and demographic information are summarized in Table 1 below.

Table 1 Demographic information of the participants

Gender	Educational degree			Course of instruction		Teaching context				
	Male	Female	B.A	M.A	Ph.D	Junior Secondary Program	Senior Secondary Program	Both	Public school	Private school
N	35	70	44	54	7	29	33	43	76	29
%	33.3	66.7	41.9	51.4	6.7	27.6	31.4	41.0	72.4	27.6

Instruments

To obtain a valid and reliable account of the participants' fairness conception, the researchers applied an already developed and validated Classroom Assessment Fairness Scale (Tofighi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023). The questionnaire comprises of 35 items that tap into the five principles of fairness in classroom assessment: (1) the chances to learn (5 items), (2) the chances to indicate learning (4 items), (3) unambiguity (5 items), (4) do-no-harm principle and productive learning environment (9 items), and (5) score pollution avoidance (12 items). The items are rated on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from "absolutely unfair" to "absolutely fair." According to the original study account, Bartlett's test of Sphericity was significant at $p < 0.01$ which indicated a strong interrelationship among items and confirms the factorability of the correlation matrix. Additionally, the composite reliability (CR) and convergent/discriminant validity of each factor were evaluated; results showed that in terms of composite reliability, all of the variables had values exceeding 0.7, indicating an admissible level of reliability (Hair et al., 2014). Moreover, confirming the scale convergent validity (Hair et al., 2014), the average variance explained (AVE) of all factors and the maximum shared variance (MSV) for all corresponding factors were safely above 0.5 and below AVE, respectively.

Procedures

This research was carried out in the context of secondary education in Iran. For the study purposes, a study participation request and the online version of the CAFS scale were sent to Iranian English teachers teaching in public and private high schools in both junior and/or senior secondary levels and of course were members of several virtual Telegram and WhatsApp Special Interest Groups (SIG). Out of hundreds of recipients, one hundred and five EFL teachers responded positively to the participation request, and once they received the necessary information about the project and were assured of the ethical clearances, they took the online version of the scale. While the completed questionnaires were arriving, the researchers embarked on initial checks and screening to safeguard the response validity of the completed questionnaires and to plan for possible follow-up inquiries if any one of the received questionnaires were partially or improperly filled out. Finally, the obtained data were analyzed using both descriptive and inferential statistics to address the research questions.

Results

The statistical analyses of the quantitative data were conducted using SPSS software. Prior to the main analyses, the normality of data distribution was checked to assess the normality of obtained scale data (Fig. 1). As is displayed below, the scatterplot documents the spread of the data around a rather straight line which confirms the normality of the data distribution.

Next, to answer the first research question, which explored Iranian high school EFL teachers' perception of fair classroom assessment practices, we employed descriptive statistical analyses. According to the results, the mean score for the *chance to learn* component ranged from 2.66 to 4.26 (Table 2). Item 2 addressing procrastination of the final exam until the comprehensive coverage of the intended material had the

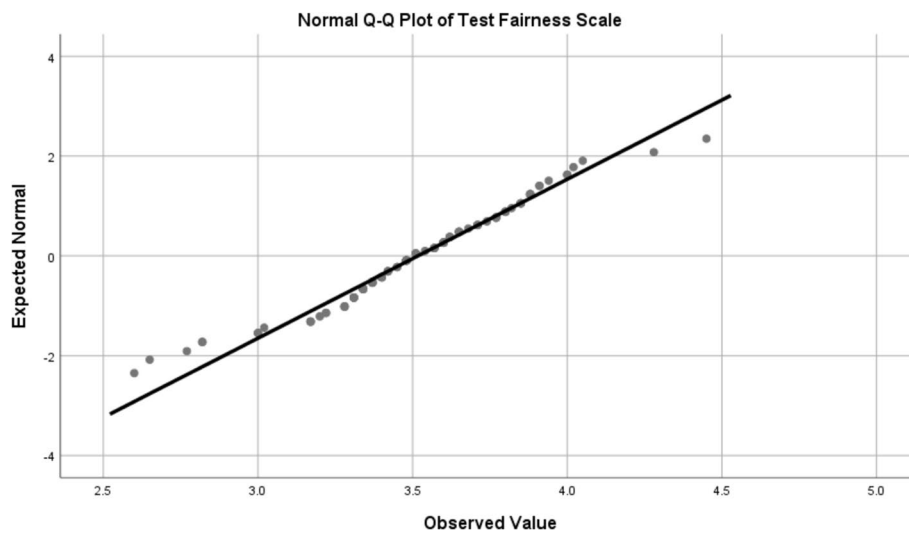


Fig. 1 Detrended normal Q-Q plot

Table 2 Descriptive statistics of chance to learn principal

Likert scale							
Item	N	Absolutely unfair	Unfair	Undecided	Fair	Absolutely fair	Mean
1. Resemblance between instructional activities and assessment items	105	2.9	3.8	9.5	46.7	37.1	4.11
2. Procrastination of final exam until complete coverage of the intended material	105	4.8	3.8	8.6	26.7	56.2	4.26
3. Including surprise items in the final exam	105	25.7	25.7	18.1	18.1	12.4	2.66
4. Administer a parallel form of the test	105	3.8	10.5	28.6	44.8	12.4	3.51
5. Using methods that students have regularly encountered	105	6.7	4.8	10.5	40.0	38.1	3.98

highest mean of 4.26, and most participants (82.9%) deemed it as fair and absolutely fair. Additionally, item 1 probing into the resemblance between instructional activities and assessment items was recognized as highly fair by most participants (83.8%). Additionally, item 3, which tapped into incorporating a number of unanticipated items in the assessment, exhibited the smallest average value of 2.66, and only 30.5% of participants endorsed the item as fair and absolutely fair.

The statistical analysis of the participants' answers to the questions of the second factor which tapped into the fairness of the provision of chances for learners to indicate what they learned revealed that items 6 and 9, referring to the inclusion of multiple forms of assessment and drawing on a range of assessment activities, exhibited the highest mean scores of 3.90 and 4.05, respectively, and the majority of participants (73.3% and 80%) endorsed fairness and complete fairness of the activities; however, the lowest mean of 3.04 belonged to item 7, i.e., applying observation as the unique method to assess, and 42.9% of participants considered it as unfair and absolutely unfair (Table 3).

Table 3 Descriptive statistics of chance to indicate learning principle

Likert scale							
Item	N	Absolutely unfair	Unfair	Undecided	Fair	Absolutely fair	Mean
6. Including multiple forms of assessment	105	4.8	9.5	12.4	38.1	35.2	3.90
7. Using observation as the unique method of assessment	105	13.3	28.6	15.2	26.7	16.2	3.04
8. Assessing oral proficiency via diverse activities	105	5.7	7.6	18.1	38.1	30.5	3.80
9. Giving students a variety of activities	105	3.8	2.9	13.3	44.8	35.2	4.05

Table 4 Descriptive statistics of unambiguity principle

Likert scale							
Item	N	Absolutely unfair	Unfair	Undecided	Fair	Absolutely fair	Mean
10. Informing students about how a task would be graded	105	4.8	5.7	9.5	39.0	41.0	4.06
11. Providing students with the rubrics for each task in advance	105	2.9	3.8	16.2	28.6	48.6	4.16
12. Maintaining the confidentiality of the students' performance assessment rubric details	105	1.9	9.5	14.3	44.8	29.5	3.90
13. Clarification of policy, procedures, and decisions	105	1.9	5.7	4.8	32.4	55.2	4.33
14. Explicitizing the policy of class attendance	105	1.9	6.7	12.4	23.8	55.2	4.24

Considering the unambiguity factor, as Table 4 indicates, item 13 exhibited the highest average value of 4.33, and 87.6% of participants approved it as fair and absolutely fair. Additionally, 79% of the participants deemed explicitizing the policy regarding class attendance fair (item 14), and 77.2% approved providing students with the guidelines for each task in advance (item 11) as fair and absolutely fair assessment practices. Further, item 10, which referred to informing students about the task grading criteria, was marked fair and absolutely fair by 80% of the participants. Nevertheless, among these items, the lowest mean (3.90) belonged to item 12 which, focusing on the confidentiality of the details of the students' performance assessment rubrics, was endorsed as unfair and absolutely unfair by only 11.4% of the participants.

As Table 5 indicates, among the items under the do-no-harm principle and productive classroom environment component, a priori announcement of the test/assessment time (item 23) exhibited the highest mean of 4.30 and was rated fair and absolutely fair by 83.% of the participants. Additionally, the fairness and absolute fairness of adapting the pace of teaching to accommodate students' comprehension levels (item 16) and respecting the privacy of students (item 21) were recognized as fair by most of the participants (83.8% and 83%, respectively). Further, they deemed spending time to inform students about the forte and foible of their performance (item 15) and demonstrating care for the academic progress of students (item 20) fair

Table 5 Descriptive statistics of do-no-harm principle and productive classroom environment

Likert scale							
Item	N	Absolutely unfair	Unfair	Undecided	Fair	Absolutely fair	Mean
15. Informing students about performance forte and foible	105	3.8	8.6	10.5	45.7	31.4	3.92
16. Adapting the pace of instruction to accommodate students' comprehension levels	105	2.9	5.7	.6	41.9	41.9	4.14
17. Sharing with students the rubrics for each specific task	105	3.8	7.6	21.9	39.0	27.6	3.79
18. Encouraging students to rate each other's assignments	105	8.6	13.3	24.8	33.3	20	3.43
19. Applying peer assessment	105	7.6	19.0	22.9	41.0	9.5	3.26
20. Demonstrating care for students' academic progress	105	2.9	4.8	6.7	54.3	31.4	4.07
21. Respecting the privacy of students	105	1.9	4.8	10.5	29.5	53.5	4.28
22. Assessing performance using alternative measures or administering a different form of the same test to students who engage in cheating	105	10.5	15.2	21.9	36.2	16.2	3.32
23. A priori announcement of the test/ assessment time	105	4.8	4.8	6.7	23.8	60	4.30

and absolutely fair assessment practices (77.1% and 85.7%, respectively). Nonetheless, around 50.5% of teachers approved the fairness and absolute fairness of applying assessment by peers, and it exhibited the lowest average value of 3.26 (item 19). Finally, item 18, which addressed encouraging students to rate the assignments of their peers, was considered fair and absolutely fair by 53.3% of participants.

Table 6 illustrates that for the score pollution avoidance factor, item 30, which addresses offering extra credit for volunteering in classroom activities, was endorsed as fair and absolutely fair by 79% of the participants and with a mean of 4.02 ranked as the highest mean. The findings revealed that only a small number of teachers approved the unfair or absolute unfairness of deducing students' grades due to late submission of assignments (34.3%), showing disruptive behavior (38.1%), selecting an incorrect answer (34.2%) (items 24, 27, and 34, respectively). Additionally, 39.1% of participants endorsed offering extra credit chances to all students except those who are already highly proficient (item 35) unfair and absolutely unfair assessment practice. On the other hand, item 26, i.e., changing students' grades based on their disruptive behavior, exhibited the lowest mean score of 2.89 and was endorsed as unfair and absolutely unfair by about 44.7% of the teachers.

Finally, the descriptive statistics for all five dimensions of CAFS revealed that the mean scores varied from 3.37 to 4.13 (Table 7). Consequently, the mean scores were 3.37 for preventing score pollution principle, 3.69 for the chances to indicate learning, 3.70 for the chances to learn component, 3.83 for the do-no-harm component and productive classroom environment, and 4.13 for the unambiguity principle. The overall mean score for teachers' perspective toward CAFS was found to be 3.51.

The second research question explored whether Iranian EFL teachers were statistically different in terms of their attitudes toward the fair assessment practices

Table 6 Descriptive statistics of prevent score pollution principle

Likert scale							
Item	N	Absolutely unfair	Unfair	Undecided	Fair	Absolutely fair	Mean
24. deducing students' grades due to late submission of assignments	105	9.5	24.8	15.2	37.1	13.3	3.20
25. Adjusting students' grades based on assessments by other instructors	105	6.7	9.5	15.2	27.6	41.0	3.87
26. Adjusting students' grades based on disruptive behavior exhibited	105	15.2	29.5	17.1	27.6	10.5	2.89
27. Modifying students' grades based on inappropriate behavior	105	7.6	30.5	20.0	31.4	10.5	3.07
28. Do not consider the level of tidiness	105	12.4	34.3	16.2	24.8	12.4	2.90
29. Assigning a portion of the grade based on students' class attendance	105	5.7	13.3	10.5	41.9	28.6	3.74
30. Offering additional credit for voluntary classroom participation	105	1.9	4.8	14.3	47.6	31.4	4.02
31. Resisting pressure put by parents to modify standards or bend rules	105	3.8	4.8	17.1	37.1	37.1	3.99
32. Determining every student's score based on the whole group performance	105	10.5	32.4	23.8	23.8	9.5	2.90
33. Including class attendance as a component of the final grade	105	6.7	10.5	16.2	45.7	20.0	3.92
34. Penalizing more for incorrect answers	105	15.2	19.0	29.5	23.8	12.4	2.99
35. Offering extra credit opportunities to all students except those who are already highly proficient	105	12.4	26.7	24.8	22.9	13.3	2.98

Table 7 Descriptive statistics for five dimensions of CAFS

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. deviation
Chance to learn	105	1.60	5.00	3.70	.64
Chance to indicate learning	105	1.75	5.00	3.69	.81
Unambiguity	105	1.40	5.00	4.13	.72
No harm principle and productive classroom environment	105	1.89	5.00	3.83	.60
Prevent score pollution	105	1.50	7.00	3.37	.64
Fairness	105	2.60	4.45	3.51	.31

considering the diverse teaching context. To answer this research question, and to compare the means of the two groups of the teachers, an independent samples *t*-test was employed. According to the preliminary analyses, no violation of the assumptions was confirmed, since Levene's test for equality of variances indicated that the variances of the two groups of teachers were not significantly different on CAFS ($p=0.6$, $p>0.05$) and normal probability plot suggested a straight line indicating no real clustering of points, with most collecting around the zero line. The *t*-test results demonstrated that the scores for public ($M=3.51$, $SD=0.31$) and private high school teachers ($M=3.53$, $SD=0.30$; $t(103) = -0.249$, $p=0.80$) were not significantly

Table 8 Independent samples t-test comparing public and private high school teachers' attitudes to CAFS

	Levene's test for equality of variances		t-test for equality of means						
	F	Sig	t	df	Sig. (2-tailed)	Mean difference	Std. error difference	95% confidence interval of the difference	
								Lower	Upper
Equal variances assumed	.173	.678	-.249	103	.804	-.017	.068	-.153	.11
Equal variances not assumed			-.255	52.84	.800	-.017	.067	-.152	.11

different on CAFS. It needs to be added that the difference in the means, i.e., mean difference = -0.017 , 95% CI [$-0.153, 0.11$] was very small (Table 8).

Discussion

This study investigated Iranian EFL teachers' perception of fair language assessment practices. The findings indicated that the teachers were fairly cognizant of and attentive to the concept. They were highly conscious of the transparency principle, quite attentive to the no-harm principle, fairly cognizant of the chance to learn, and the chance to indicate learning principles. However, the results indicated that the teachers were only rather mindful of the preventing score pollution principle. The finding is in contrast with Almosa and Alzahrani (2022) claiming that among the four dimensions of teachers' assessment approaches within the classroom, i.e., assessment purposes, processes, fairness, and measurement theory, fairness was the least valued aspect from Saudi Arabian teachers' standpoint.

Concerning the chance to learn principle, absolute majority of participants deemed procrastinating the final exam till complete material coverage, applying the same methods regularly encountered by students and congruence between classroom activities and test items as completely fair. Generally, they unanimously verified the significance of curriculum and assessment alignment. This is an approval to the *content representativeness or coverage evidence* in Kunnan's (2008) TFF which refers to the adequacy with which the test items, tasks, topics, and language varieties reflect the content and scope of the test domain and further confirms the findings of earlier studies which have confirmed the assessment of learners on the basis of what they have learned and mastered as a fair practice (McMillan, 2011; Rasooli et al., 2019; Russell & Airasian, 2012; Tierney, 2014, 2016; Tofghi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023; Torkey & Sayed Haider, 2017). However, the inclusion of surprise items in the final exam was regarded as completely unfair by a great many of EFL teachers that is in contrast with the studies that reported the incorporation of a few surprise items in assessment as fair and equitable (Fan et al., 2017, 2020; Liu et al., 2016; Tofghi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023). Considering the opportunity to indicate learning principle, offering students diverse activities, including various forms of assessment, and assessing oral proficiency via diverse activities were deemed quite fair by most of the teachers. The teachers were positive with incorporating multiple forms of assessment, i.e., adopting alternative assessment methods and drawing on a range of activities and negative with the application of observation as the sole method for learner assessment, that is in line with the *absence of bias and disparate impact evidence* principle in Kunnan's (2008) TFF which emphasizes that test takers from different demographic groups vary in their performance levels and resulting outcomes, consequently differential validity analysis is inevitable to examine the test efficiency in addressing the learners' differences and predicting their success, and verifies what has been supported in recent studies like Alm and Colnerud (2015), Liu et al. (2016), Fan et al. (2019), Fan et al. (2020), Green et al. (2007), Scott et al. (2014), Tierney (2016), Tofghi and Ahmadi Safa (2023), and Rezaei et al. (2021).

Considering the unambiguity principle, the results indicated that clarifying policies, procedures, and decisions as well as illuminating the policy of the class attendance, a priori sharing of the rubrics of tasks, and stating how a task would be graded were

considered quite fair by a great number of teachers. The attested transparency in policy and procedures verifies the finding of Tierney (2014), Rezaei et al. (2021), and Tofighi and Ahmadi Safa (2023), who argued that teachers supported precedential informing of the learners about the learning requirements and assessment criteria. Prior communication of grading method to the learners was welcomed by Tierney (2016) and Tofighi and Ahmadi Safa (2023) as well, reporting that learners should be informed of the criteria by which their work will be evaluated prior to an assessment. However, regarding the students' performance assessment rubrics, the teachers were pretty pessimistic about confidentiality which disconfirms Tofighi and Ahmadi Safa (2023) who reported that EFL teachers were optimistic about keeping performance assessment rubric confidential, and confirms both Fan et al. (2020) who reported that students favored ethicality of their involvement in the process of developing assessment standards and Rezaei et al. (2021), who reported teachers' adherence to involving students in the assessment process.

Regarding the do-no-harm and productive classroom environment principle, descriptive statistics revealed that announcing the test/assessment time in advance and respecting the privacy of students was regarded as completely fair by most of the teachers, which is consistent with Gordon and Fay (2010), Tofighi and Ahmadi Safa (2023), Wendorf and Alexander (2005) who highlighted the importance of respecting students' privacy as a fair assessment practice.

Contrary to the researchers' expectation to avoid the score pollution component, the results confirmed that modifying the learners' scores considering teachers' alternative perspectives on them was reckoned as completely fair. This finding supports the findings of Alm and Colnerud (2015), Murillo and Hidalgo (2017), Duncan and Noonan (2007), Scott et al. (2014), Resh (2009), Liu et al. (2016), Tierney (2015), Torkey and Sayed Haider (2017), and Tofighi and Ahmadi Safa (2023) on teachers' inclination to incorporate secondary or contributing factors into assessment and evaluation and goes against the idea that learners' scores should only reflect factors relevant to the construct and not be influenced by irrelevant (Green et al., 2007; Hermen & Cook, 2019) or underrepresented factors (Rasooli et al., 2018).

The obtained data regarding the second research question uncovered that the teaching context did not significantly affect how Iranian EFL teachers perceived fair language assessment practices. Accordingly, both public and private high school EFL teachers had the same amount of awareness toward fairness in their practices. This contrasts with previous researches, which emphasized the impact of contextual variables on the way teachers perceive constitutions of fair assessment (Murillo & Hidalgo, 2020; Rezaei et al., 2022; Rubie-Davies et al., 2012; Tofighi & Ahmadi Safa, 2023).

Conclusion and implication

This study investigated Iranian English teachers' perceptions of classroom assessment fairness in both publicly funded and private high schools. The findings indicated that the teachers were quite mindful of the four components of fairness in assessment practices, i.e., the provision of chances to learn, to indicate learning, the do-no-harm principle, and the productive learning environment, as well as the unambiguity principle, though their awareness of avoiding score pollution was a bit lower than the other principles. Further, the findings indicated that regardless of the teaching context, Iranian EFL teachers confirmed the vital

role of fairness in their assessment practices. Such findings extend our knowledge regarding the significance of the ethicality in educational assessment practices. However, the findings might suggest that professional development programs and opportunities focusing on the development of the teachers' understanding of what pollutes their assessment and scoring process could be beneficial. Additionally, encouraging open dialogue among educators of both contexts to discuss and share their typical assessment practices can further enrich the fairness of assessment practices in educational settings. Finally, since perceptions do not significantly differ, the assessment practices or strategies that are deemed fair by one group might be applicable or transferable to the other group without major incompatibility or discordance. The findings of this study ought to be cautiously applied due to a number of the study limitations. As for a major one, the researchers are recommended to consider that the concept of fairness in assessment practice was investigated in terms of the EFL teachers' conceptions and not directly in their classroom assessment practices. Future research could benefit from incorporating classroom observations by independent observers and correlating these observations with teachers' perceptions. Furthermore, the participants in this study were merely delimited to the EFL teachers from public and private high schools. Future research might benefit from the inclusion of more heterogeneous and representative sample of EFL teachers in different educational contexts.

Abbreviations

AERA	American Educational Research Association
AVE	Average variance explained
CA	Classroom assessment
CAFS	Classroom Assessment Fairness Scale
CR	Composite reliability
EFL	English as a Foreign Language
MSV	Maximum shared variance
NCD	National Curriculum Document
SIG	Special Interest Group
TFF	Test Fairness Framework

Acknowledgements

The authors heartily appreciate the cooperation of the participant teachers without which the project would not have come to an end.

Authors' contributions

Both authors equally contributed to the completion of the study. A substantial contribution was made by Dr. Mohammad Ahmadi Safa in data curation, data analysis, and interpretation, as well as the composition of the final manuscript. Ms. Bahare Nasiri also made her equal contribution to the study during different phases of the investigation. Both authors also read and approved the final manuscript.

Funding

The project was funded by Bu-Ali Sina University, Iran.

Data availability

The authors state that all the data supporting the findings of this study are available within the article.

Declarations

Competing interests

The authors declare that they have no competing interests.

Received: 13 September 2024 Accepted: 8 December 2024

Published online: 06 January 2025

References

Airasian, P. (2005). *Assessment in the classroom: A concise approach* (2nd ed.). McGraw-Hill Company.

- Alm, F., & Colnerud, G. (2015). Teachers' experiences of unfair grading. *Educational Assessment*, 20(2), 132–150. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10627197.2015.1028620>
- Almosa, S. Y., & Alzahrani, S. M. (2022). Assessment approaches of English language teachers in the Saudi higher education context. *Language Testing in Asia*, 12(1). <https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-022-00160-x>
- American Educational Research Association (AERA), American Psychological Association (APA), & National Council on Measurement in Education (NCME). (2014). Standards for educational and psychological testing. Washington, DC: American Educational Research Association, American Psychological Association, & National Council on Measurement in Education.
- American Educational Research Association, Association, A. P., Council, N., & on Measurement in Education. (1999). *Standards for educational and psychological testing*. American Educational Research Association.
- Azizi, Z. (2022). Fairness in assessment practices in online education: Iranian university English teachers' perceptions. *Language Testing in Asia*, 12(14), 1–17. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-022-00164-7>
- Bahrami, M., & Moradkhani, Sh. (2019). A comparison of public school and private institute EFL teachers' burnout. *Tech. Edu. J.* 13(3), 626–637. <https://doi.org/10.22061/jte.2018.3542.1890>
- Camilli, G. (2013). Ongoing issues in test fairness. *Educational Research and Evaluation*, 9, 104–120. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13803611.2013.767602>
- Camilli, G. (2006). Test fairness. In R. Brennan (Ed.), *Educational measurement*, (4th Ed., pp. 221–256). American Council on Education /Praeger.
- Chory-Assad, R. M. (2002). Classroom justice: Perceptions of fairness as a predictor of student motivation, learning, and aggression. *Communication Quarterly*, 50(1), 58–77. <https://doi.org/10.1080/01463370209385646>
- Chory-Assad, R. M. (2007). Enhancing student perceptions of fairness: The relationship between instructor credibility and classroom justice. *Communication Education*, 56(1), 89–105. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03634520600994300>
- Chory-Assad, R. M., & Paulsel, M. L. (2004). Classroom justice: Student aggression and resistance as reactions to perceived unfairness. *Communication Education*, 53(3), 253–273.
- Cole, N. S., & Zieky, M. J. (2001). The new faces of fairness. *Journal of Educational Measurement*, 38(4), 369–382.
- Darabi Bazvand, A., & Rasooli, A. (2022). Students' experiences of fairness in summative assessment: A study in a higher education context. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, 72, 101118. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.stueduc.2021.101118>
- Duncan, C. R., & Noonan, B. (2007). Factors affecting teachers' grading and assessment practices. *Alberta Journal of Educational Research*, 53(1), 1–21. <https://doi.org/10.11575/ajerv53i1.55195>
- Educational Testing Service. (2014). *ETS standards for quality and fairness*. Educational Testing Service.
- Elwood, J., & Murphy, P. (2015). Assessment systems as cultural scripts: A sociocultural theoretical lens on assessment practice and products. *Assessment in Education: Principles, Policy & Practice*, 22, 182–192. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594X.2015.1021568>
- Fan, X., Liu, X., & Johnson, R. (2020). A mixed method study of ethical issues in classroom assessment in Chinese higher education. *Asia Pacific Education Review*, 21, 183–195. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s12564-019-09623-y>
- Fan, X., Johnson, R., & Liu, X. (2017). Chinese university professors' perceptions about ethical issues in classroom assessment practices. *New Waves Educational Research & Development*, 20(2), 1–19. <https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/EJ1211389.pdf>
- Fan, X., Johnson, R., Liu, X., Zhang, X., Liu, X., & Zhang, T. (2019). A comparative study of pre-service teachers' views on ethical issues in classroom assessment in China and the United States. *Frontiers of Education in China*, 14(2), 309–32. <https://link.springer.com/article/https://doi.org/10.1007/s11516-019-0015-7>
- Flores, M. A., Veiga Simao, A. M., Barros, A., & Pereira, D. (2015). Perceptions of effectiveness, fairness and feedback of assessment methods: A study in higher education. *Studies in Higher Education*, 40(9), 1523–1534. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03075079.2014.881348>
- Gordon, M. E., & Fay, C. H. (2010). The effects of grading and teaching practices on students' perceptions of grading fairness. *College Teaching*, 58(3), 93–98. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/41305091>
- Green, S., Johnson, R., Kim, D., & Pope, N. (2007). Ethics in classroom assessment practices: Issues and attitudes. *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 23(7), 999–1011. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tate.2006.04.042>
- Hair, J. F. J., Hult, G. T. M., Ringle, C., & Sarstedt, M. (2014). *A primer on partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM)*. Sage Publication.
- Haladyna, T. M., Nolen, S. B., & Haas, N. S. (1991). Raising standardized achievement test scores and the origins of test score pollution. *Educational Researcher*, 20, 2–7.
- Herman, J., & Cook, L. (2019). Fairness in classroom assessment. In S. M. Brookhart & J. H. McMillan (Eds.), *Classroom assessment and educational measurement* (pp. 243–264). Routledge.
- Kunnan, A. J., et al. (1997). Connecting validation and fairness in language testing. In A. Huhta (Ed.), *Current developments and alternatives in language assessment* (pp. 85–105). University of Jyväskylä.
- Kunnan, A. J. (2008). Towards a model of test evaluation: Using the test fairness and wider context frameworks. In L. Taylor, & C. Weir (Eds.), *Multilingualism and assessment: Achieving transparency, assuring quality, sustaining diversity* (pp. 229–251). Papers from the ALTE Conference in Berlin, Germany, CUP.
- Lane, S., & Silver, E. A. (1999). Fairness and equity in measuring student learning using a mathematics performance assessment: Results from the quasar project. In A. L. Nettles & M. T. Nettles (Eds.), *Measuring up: Challenges minorities face in educational assessment* (pp. 97–120). Kluwer Academic Publishers.
- Liu, J., Johnson, R., & Fan, X. (2016). A comparative study of Chinese and United States pre-service teachers' perceptions about ethical issues in classroom assessment. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, 48, 57–66. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.stueduc.2016.01.002>
- Mazzoli Smith, L., Todd, L., & Laing, K. (2018). Students' views on fairness in education: The importance of relational justice and stakes fairness. *Research Papers in Education*, 33, 336–353. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02671522.2017.1302500>
- McMillan, J. H. (2011). *Classroom assessment: Principles and practice for effective standards-based instruction* (5th Ed). Pearson Education Inc.

- Messick, S. (2000). Consequences of test interpretation and use: The fusion of validity and values in psychological assessment. In R. D. Goffin & E. Helmes (Eds.), *Problems and solutions in human assessment* (pp. 3–20). Kluwer Academic Publishers.
- Messick, S., & Anderson, S. (1970). Educational testing, individual development, and social responsibility. *The Counseling Psychologist*, 2(2), 80–88.
- Messick, S. (1988). Consequences of test interpretation and use: The fusion of validity and values in psychological assessment. Paper presented at the International Congress of Applied Psychology. ETS Research Report, RR-98–48. Princeton, New Jersey. San Francisco, CA: Educational Testing Service.
- Mislevy, R. J. (2018). *Sociocognitive foundations of educational measurement*. Routledge.
- Moss, P. A., Pullin, D., Gee, J. P., & Haertel, E. H. (2005). The idea of testing: Psychometric and sociocultural perspectives. *Measurement: Interdisciplinary Research and Perspectives*, 3, 63–83. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15366359mea0302_1
- Murillo, F. J., & Hidalgo, N. (2017). Students' conceptions about a fair assessment of their learning. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, 53, 10–16. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.stueduc.2017.01.001>
- Murillo, F. J., & Hidalgo, N. (2020). Fair student assessment: A phenomenographic study on teachers' conceptions. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, 65, 1–10. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.stueduc.2020.100860>
- Naeem Akhtar, Sh., Amir Hashmi, M., & Hussain Naqvi, S. I. (2010). A comparative study of job satisfaction in public and private school teachers at secondary level. *Procedia - Social and Behavioral Sciences*, 2(2), 4222–4228. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.sbspro.2010.03.668>
- Ministry of Education. (2010). National Curriculum Document (NCD) of the Islamic Republic of Iran.
- Nisbet, I. (2017). Fairness takes center stage. *Assessment in Education: Principles, Policy & Practice*, 26(1), 1–7. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594X.2017.1358151>
- Nisbet, I. (2019). Fairness takes center stage. *Assessment in Education Principles Policy and Practice*, 26(1), 111–117. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594X.2017.1358151>
- Nisbet, I., & Shaw, D. S. (2019). Fair assessment viewed through the lenses of measurement theory. *Assessment in Education Principles Policy and Practice*, 26(5), 612–629. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594X.2019.1586643>
- Peters, R., Kruse, J., Buckmiller, T., & Townsley, M. (2017). It's just not fair! Making sense of secondary students' resistance to a standards-based grading. *American Secondary Education*, 45(3), 9–27.
- Popham, W. J. (1991). Appropriateness of teachers' test preparation practices. *Educational Measurement: Issues and Practice*, 10(4), 12–15.
- Rasooli, A., Zandi, H., & DeLuca, C. (2018). Re-conceptualizing classroom assessment fairness: A systematic meta-ethnography of assessment literature and beyond. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, 56, 164–181. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.stueduc.2017.12.008>
- Rasooli, A., DeLuca, C., Resegh, A., & Fathi, S. (2019). Students' critical incidents of fairness in classroom assessment: An empirical study. *Social Psychology of Education*, 22, 701–722. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11218-019-09491-9>
- Rasooli, A., Resegh, A., Zandi, H., & Firoozi, T. (2022). Teachers' conceptions of fairness in classroom assessment: An empirical study. *Journal of Teacher Education*, 74(3), 260–273. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00224871221130742>
- Resh, N. (2009). Justice in grades allocation: Teachers' perspective. *Social Psychology of Education*, 12(3), 315–25. <https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007%2Fs11218-008-9073-z>
- Rezaei, A., Alibakhshi, G., Farokhipour, S., & Miri, M. (2021). A phenomenographic study on language assessment literacy: Hearing from Iranian university teachers. *Language Testing Asia*, 11, 1–25. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-021-00142-5>
- Rezaei, A., Namaziandost, E., Miri, M., & Kumar, T. (2022). Demographic biases and assessment fairness in classroom: Insights from Iranian university teachers. *Language Testing in Asia*, 12(1), 1–20. <https://doi.org/10.1186/s40468-022-00157-6>
- Rogers, W. T. (1996). Principles for fair student assessment practices for education in Canada. *Assessment in Education Principles Policy and Practice*, 3(3), 397–400. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594960030308>
- Rubie-Davies, C. M., Flint, A. Y., & McDonald, L. G. (2012). Teacher beliefs, teacher characteristics, and school contextual factors: What are the relationships? *British Journal of Educational Psychology*, 82(2), 270–288. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.2044-8279.2011.02025.x>
- Russell, M. K. & Airasian, P. W. (2012). CA: Concepts and applications (7th Ed). McGraw-Hill Higher Education.
- Scott, S., Webber, C. F., Lupart, J. L., Aitken, N., & Scott, D. E. (2014). Fair and equitable assessment practices for all students. *Assessment in Education: Principles, Policy & Practice*, 21(1), 52–70. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0969594X.2013.776943>
- Shah Ahmadi, M., & Ketabi, S. (2019). Features of language assessment literacy in Iranian English language teachers' perceptions and practices. *Teaching English as a Second Language Quarterly (Formerly Journal of Teaching Language Skills)*, 38(1), 191–223. <https://doi.org/10.22099/jtls.2020.34843.2739>
- Shiba, Y., Umegaki, H., & Sugawara, T. (2015). Fair assessment of group work by mutual evaluation with irresponsible and collusive students using trust networks. In Q. Chen, P. Torroni, S. Villata, J. Hsu, & A. Omicini (Vol. Eds.), *PRIMA 2015: Principles and practice of multi-agent systems*: 9387. Cham: Springer.
- Stobart, G. (2005). Fairness in multicultural assessment systems. *Assessment in Education: Principles, Policy & Practice*, 12(3), 275–287.
- Suskie, L. (2002). Fair assessment practices: Giving students equitable opportunities to demonstrate learning. *Adventures in Assessment*, 14, 5–10.
- Taylor, K. & Nolen, S. (2005). Classroom assessment: Supporting teaching and learning in real classrooms. Pearson Education.
- Thompson, A. G. (1992). Teachers' beliefs and conceptions: A synthesis of the research. In D. A. Grouws (Ed.), *Handbook of research on mathematics teaching and learning* (pp. 127–146). Macmillan.
- Tierney, R. (2013). Fairness in classroom assessment. In J. H. McMillan (Ed.), *Sage handbook of research on classroom assessment* (pp. 125–144). SAGE Publications.
- Tierney, R. (2014). Fairness as a multifaceted quality in classroom assessment. *Studies in Educational Evaluation*, 43, 55–69. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.stueduc.2013.12.003>

- Tierney, R. (2016). Fairness in educational assessment. In M. A. Peters (Ed.), *Encyclopedia of educational philosophy and theory* (pp. 1–6). Springer Singapore.
- Tierney, R. (2015). Altered grades: A grey zone in the ethics of classroom assessment. *Assessment Matters*, 8, 5–30. <https://doi.org/10.18296/am.0002>.
- Tofighi, S., & Ahmadi Safa, M. (2023). Fairness in classroom language assessment from EFL teachers' perspective. *Teaching English as a Second Language Quarterly (Formerly Journal of Teaching Language Skills)*, 42(2), 81–110. <https://doi.org/10.22099/tesl.2023.46825.3173>.
- Torkey, S. A., & Sayed Haider, N. A. (2017). Ethicality in EFL classroom assessment: Bridging the gap between theory and practice. In S. Hidri & C. Coombe (Eds.), *Evaluation in foreign language education in the Middle East and North Africa* (pp. 59–85). Springer.
- Wendorf, C. A., & Alexander, S. (2005). The influence of individual- and class-level fairness-related perceptions on student satisfaction. *Contemporary Educational Psychology*, 30(2), 190–206. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cedpsych.2004.07.003>

Publisher's Note

Springer Nature remains neutral with regard to jurisdictional claims in published maps and institutional affiliations.